

Faggots

The same renders account for 1,200 faggots received at Northwode from the afore-said felled oaks. And for 300 faggots at Esher from trees felled in La Crumbe. Sum 1,500. Of which in expenses of the lord for his coming there on the way towards the parliament of the lord king in London 300. And sold 1,200.

26. 29 September 1325 to 29 September 1326

Climatic change is often accompanied by extreme and changeable weather conditions and in the 1320s a new phase of weather conditions took hold, characterised not by torrential rain but by severe drought.⁴²⁶ Droughts had occurred in 1323 and 1325 but the author of the *Annales Paulini* – who was based in London – believed that the drought of 1326 was ‘unprecedented’.⁴²⁷ Indeed, in the Esher account for 1325/6, meadow at Northwode was not mown ‘since there was a drought at summer-time’; even the number of willow withies that were sold was reduced that year for the same reason. Drought could potentially affect agricultural fortunes and animal and human health in a numbers of ways. Certainly, tenants at Esher appear to have been sensitive to these conditions, especially given the cumulative impact of the problems of the preceding decade. In the three years 1324/5, 1325/6, and 1326/7 there was a sudden influx of heriots received, the contextual details of which are as telling as the numbers themselves. In this account, for example, we learn that the heriot paid after the (specified) death of Richard Walerond was merely a supertunic rather than an animal. Moreover, some of the holdings that were passed on were pathetically small: that which Nicholas le Creller inherited from his father, consisted only of a cottage with its curtilage and $\frac{1}{4}$ acre of land; notably, the next entry reveals that a heriot paid by the same family, presumably for this surrender, amounted to the value of a calf, rather than the calf itself. The account for 1325/6 is illuminating in two further ways. First, more prosaically, it contains an unusual amount of information about the organisation of the manorial landscape, not least with respect to the nature of Dounwode, the distinction between different areas of woodland, and the location of surviving vines. More remarkably, it also contains a reference to snakes, which appear to have taken up residence in the lord’s stable. Snakes, whether adders or grass snakes, may have been driven closer to human and animal habitation by the drought, though it is also possible that manure from the stable was being removed more assiduously than usual (given the lack of other livestock) and that a nest had been disturbed. A similar reference occurs in the account for 1329/30, when 18 customary tenants removed manure from the *curia* over the course of 22 days, ‘by order of the lord’, because ‘many snakes were discovered’ there.⁴²⁸ See Plates 3a and 3b for photos of the original account for 1325/6.

HRO, 11M59/B1/79, rot 36r, 36v.

⁴²⁶ For an analysis of the agricultural and demographic implications of drought in this period, see Stone, ‘Impact of drought’.

⁴²⁷ Stubbs, ed., *Chronicles*, I, pp. 312–13.

⁴²⁸ HRO, 11M59/B1/83.

Arrears

Gilbert le Forestar, reeve, renders account for 34s 6¼d of arrears from the last account of the preceding year. Sum as shown.

Rent of assize

And for 10s 3d received from rent of assize at the feast of the Invention of the Cross [3 May]. And for 111s 7½d received from rent at the term of St Michael. Sum £6 22½d.

Acquittances and defects

Of which in acquittance of rent of the reeve for 1 virgate of land for the year 3s. Likewise in defect for a certain house and land pertaining to the church drawn into demesne 20s. In defect for 1 rood of meadow formerly of Legarda atte Hulle drawn into demesne 1d. Likewise in defect of rent for 1 rood of meadow formerly of Albreda atte Hulle drawn into demesne 1d. Sum of acquittances and defects 23s 2d.

Sum of net rent remaining £4 18s 8½d.

Rent of the hall of Kingston

And for 2s received from rent of the hall of Kingston this year and not more because it is broken down and unroofed so none hire it. Sum as shown.

Issue of the manor

And for 3s from mast charged at the audit. And for 18s received from all winter and summer pasture at Northwode sold. And for 6d received from pasture in \La/ Crumbe sold. And for 6d from pasture in La Frich. And for 4d from pasture in Churgrave sold. From pasture in La More nothing because depastured by the lord's animals. And for 2s received from pasture in Longeforlong. And for 3s 7d received from agistment of animals in Donnwode and not more this year because a certain furlong⁴²⁹ called La Cleye, adjacent to this, was sown this year. From pasture in the garden nothing because it was depastured by the horses of the manor and by other of the lord's affers coming in. From pasture in Buldecompe nothing because it is being sown with oats. And for 15d received from 5 cocks and 5 hens sold, owing from a certain rent called 'churchscot'. And for 20d received from small withies of willow sold and not more this year because⁴³⁰ of the dryness of the time many were lacking. And for 8d received from the fishery of \at/ Northwode. And for 4s received from the lactage of 1 cow with calf put out to lease. And for 10d received from the lactage of 5 goats put out to lease. Sum 36s 4d.

Sale of corn

And for 17s 10½d received from 4 quarters 1 bushel of rye sold, price of a quarter 4s 4d. And for 19s 10½d received from 9 quarters 7½ bushels of oats sold, price of a quarter 2s. Sum 37s 9d.

⁴²⁹ In MS, 'cultur'.

⁴³⁰ In MS, the scribe wrote 'p[ro]pt[er]', then inserted 'q[ui]a' as well.

Perquisites of court

And for 8s received from a fixed payment at the view of frankpledge there for tithingpenny at the tourns of St Martin and Hockday. And for 3s from the heriot of Richard Walerond, deceased, for one old supertunic. And for 2s received from William Walerond for having one messuage with a curtilage containing $\frac{1}{2}$ rood of land in Esher, which were Richard, his brother's. And for 2s received from John Tebaud for having one croft, a cottage, $1\frac{1}{2}$ acres of land surrendered by William \de/ Wexford. And for 12d from Alice Derling for having $\frac{1}{2}$ acre of land there surrendered by William de Wexford. And for 5s 2d from perquisites \of the tourn/ of St Martin. And for 13s 4d received from Richard de Boleworth for having one messuage and 1 virgate of land that were Robert de Boleworth his father's. And for 12d from Nicholas le Creller for having one cottage and one curtilage, 1 rood of land that were Roger his father's. And for 12d received from 1 calf from the heriot of the same Nicholas,⁴³¹ in value. And for 18d received from William Derling for having 1 acre of land surrendered by William \de/ Wexford. And for 12d received from William Hebard for having one cottage with a curtilage containing $\frac{1}{2}$ acre of land surrendered by John Edrych. And for 3s from the perquisites of the tourn of Hockday. And for 6d received from John le Brewer of Kingston for breaking the assize of ale. Sum 42s 6d.

Sales at the audit

And for 10s 9½d from various things sold at the audit. Sum as shown.

Sum of all receipts with arrears £13 2s 7¼d.

Payment of rent

In payment to the abbey and convent of Chertsey for the land of Northwode at the feast of St Michael 6s. Likewise in two ploughshares bought and paid there 18d. Sum 7s 6d.

Cost of ploughs

In iron and steel bought for maintaining the plough for the year, together with the stipend of a smith 3s 6d. In one plough foot 4d. In one ploughshare bought 9d. In fitting one old plough with a chip 1d. In making one new plough from the lord's timber 3d. Sum 4s 11d.

Cost of carts

In eight clouts with nails for the same bought for the cart 8d. Likewise in shoeing 2 cart horses for the year 12d. Sum 20d.

Purchase of corn

In 1 quarter 3 bushels of wheat bought for seed 8s, price of a quarter 6s and price of 3 bushels 2s. Likewise in 6 bushels of rye bought 2s 6d, price of a bushel 5d. Likewise in 9 quarters 2 bushels of barley bought for payment of the *famuli* 34s 3d,

⁴³¹ As no land was surrendered by Nicholas, this is presumably a scribal error for 'Roger'.

of which $6\frac{1}{2}$ quarters were bought for 26s, price of a quarter 4s, and 2 quarters 6 bushels were bought for 8s 3d, price of a bushel $4\frac{1}{2}$ d. Sum 42s 3d.

Purchase of stock

In 2 young steers bought for ploughing 17s 2d. Sum as shown.

Weeding and mowing

In weeding all the demesne corn besides the help of the *famuli* 6d. In expenses of customary tenants mowing the meadow of La Brodemed: bread from stock; in 1 wether bought for an accompaniment for the same by custom 12d; in cheese bought for the same 3d. In the meadow at Esher named Hullemed with the meadow of La Lak next to Crumbe and the meadow of Legarda atte Hulle, containing in all 3 acres, 18d.⁴³² In spreading, turning, and pitching all the said hay, besides the help of the *famuli* 6d. In carriage of hay from La Brodemed: bread from stock; in herrings bought for an accompaniment for the same 4d. And for $2\frac{1}{2}$ acres of meadow at Northwode, which was usually mowed, he accounts for nothing this year because it was not mown because of drought at summertime and therefore it was sold as above with the pasture. Sum 4s 1d.

Cost of harvest

In two boonworks, each boonwork of 22 men, who reaped and bound all the corn at Esher, besides $2\frac{1}{2}$ acres of wheat: bread from stock; in 264 herrings bought for an accompaniment for the same 2s $2\frac{1}{2}$ d, price of a hundred 10d, and each had in a day three herrings at noon and three herrings at dinner; in cheese bought for the same 8d. In candles 1d. In $2\frac{1}{2}$ acres of wheat/ at Esher, 3 acres of oats at Northwode by piecework 2s 6d, for an acre of wheat 6d and for an acre of oats 5d.⁴³³ In expenses of the reeve for harvest 2s. In one man hired for four days to carry and bring in the lord's corn at harvest time 12d, taking for a day 3d, because the manorial carter was at Southwark for the business of the same. Sum 8s 5d.

New fol. Cost of the fold

In 12 hurdles bought for the fold, for the goats there, 18d, price of a hurdle $1\frac{1}{2}$ d. Sum as shown.

Small necessities and repairs to buildings

In one carpenter hired for repairing the fence next to the hall 4d. In nails bought for the same 4d. In one roofer with his boy hired for $2\frac{1}{2}$ days to roof on the grange and the oxshed at Northwode $12\frac{1}{2}$ d, taking for himself and the boy for the day 5d. In one lock with a key bought for the door of the clerks' chamber 3d. In making five cribs⁴³⁴ of new construction in the stable, delivered by piecework, 13d. In pruning the vines opposite the hall $6\frac{1}{2}$ d. In fencing one hedged enclosure next to Dounwode measuring 114 perches, delivered by piecework, 3s 2d, for 3 perches 1d. In fencing 55 perches of hedged enclosure at Northwode opposite the land of le Beker, delivered inclusively, 2s. Likewise in fencing one hedged enclosure between the wood

⁴³² There is no verb in this sentence, but these meadows were plainly mown.

⁴³³ There is no verb in this sentence.

⁴³⁴ The scribe wrote '*chachi*' rather than '*crach*'.

of Dounwode and the land that is called La Cleye measuring 72 perches, because it was to be sown with wheat, delivered by piecework, 2s. In one basket bought 5d. In one seed-lepe⁴³⁵ bought 2d. In one lock bought for the lord's chamber 4d. In one lock bought for the door of the bakehouse 3d. In one carpenter hired for four days⁴³⁶ to make three screens in the lord's chamber and⁴³⁷ to repair the wall of the stable, the door of the grange, the gate at Dounwode 16d. Likewise in one worker hired for four days to plaster with clay⁴³⁸ the walls of the clerks' chamber, the broken down wall of the stable, and elsewhere where it was necessary 8d, for a day 2d. Likewise in cleaning the lord's stable of manure because of a suspicion of snakes⁴³⁹ 4d. In one man hired for four days for cleaning the outside chamber of the gardener and another six chambers below the *curia* 6d. Likewise in one ditch scoured between Inwode and Outwode measuring 27 perches in total 2s 6d, by order of the steward. In making 700 faggots at Northwode for the expenses of the lord, for the bakehouse and for brewing, 2s 7½d, for a hundred 4½d. Sum 19s 10½d.

Stipend of the famuli

In stipend of one ploughholder, that for a time was the carter, and one ploughdriver for the year 10s. Sum as shown.

Threshing and winnowing

In threshing 6 quarters 2 bushels of rye 12½d, for a quarter 2d. In threshing 2 quarters 5 bushels of barley by piecework 4d. In threshing 26 quarters 1 bushel of oats by piecework 2s 2d, for a quarter 1d. In winnowing all the said corn, namely in total 35 quarters 8¾d, for each quarter ¼d. Sum 4s 3¼d.

Expenses of the steward

In expenses of the steward, by a signed document, 4s 7d. Likewise in expenses of the same coming to Esher on the 18th day of June for holding the tourn of Hockday⁴⁴⁰ 5s 1d, by signed document. Sum 9s 8d.

Sum of all expenses £6 11s 3¼d.

And thus he owes £6 11s 3½d.

Payment of money

Of which he paid by tally 100s.

And he owes net 31s 3½d.

Wheat

The same answers for 1 quarter 3 bushels of wheat received from purchase. Sum as shown. Of which accounted for in seed over 5 acres of land at Esher 1 quarter 2

⁴³⁵ A basket for carrying seed.

⁴³⁶ The scribe wrote 'd' rather than 'dies'.

⁴³⁷ 'Et' is repeated.

⁴³⁸ In MS, 'lut[um]'.

⁴³⁹ In MS, 'p[ro] dubiet[ando] colubr[orum]'.

⁴⁴⁰ Hockday in fact fell on 1 April this year.

bushels, \over an acre 2 bushels/. Sold at the audit 1 bushel for 8d. Sum as above. And it equals.

It Rye

answers And for 6 quarters 2 bushels of rye received from issue by tally against Thomas de
 $\times 2\frac{1}{2}$ less Sandone, threshed. And for 6 bushels bought. Sum 7 quarters. Of which in seed over
 $2\frac{1}{2}$ bu. 2 acres in La Deneslond and over 4 acres in Ruyhulle, namely over 6 acres of land, 1½ quarters, over an acre 2 bushels. In bread baked for the expenses of customary tenants harrowing the lord's land at Lenten sowing 1 bushel. In expenses of customary tenants mowing the lord's meadows there 3 bushels. Likewise in expenses of the same carrying hay 1 bushel. Likewise in expenses of the same for two boon-works in harvest by custom 6 bushels. Sold 4 quarters 1 bushel. Sum as above. And it equals.

Barley

And for 2 quarters 6 bushels of barley received from issue by tally. And for 9 quarters 2 bushels received from purchase. Sum 12 quarters. Of which in seed over 2 acres in Ruyhulle 1 quarter. In payment of two *famuli* for the whole year, namely one plough-holder and one ploughdriver, 10 quarters 3 bushels, taking a quarter for 10 weeks. Likewise in payment of one boy guarding the lord's goats at the time of giving birth 2 bushels, for 16 weeks. Sold at the audit 3 bushels for 15d. Sum as above. And it equals.

It Oats

answers And for 30 quarters of oats received from issue at Esher and Northwode. And for
 $\times 2$. 1½ quarters received by estimation in sheaves. Sum 31 quarters 4 bushels. Of which in seed over 25 acres of land at Esher and Northwode 13 quarters 3 bushels, over an acre 4 bushels, plus in total 7 bushels. In fodder for two \horses/ stots from the feast of the Purification [2 February] until the feast of the Annunciation of the Blessed Mary [25 March] on occasion 1 quarter. In fodder for 6 oxen by estimation in sheaves 1½ quarters. In flour for pottage for the *famuli* 1 quarter 2 bushels. Sold 9 quarters 7½ bushels. Sold at the audit 4 quarters 3½ bushels for 8s 10½d. Sum as above. And it equals.

Horses

And for 2 horses received that remained. Sum as shown. And 2 horses remain.

Oxen

And for 6 oxen that remained. Sum as shown. And 6 oxen remain.

Young steers

And for 2 young steers received that remained. Sum as shown. And 2 young steers remain.

Cows

And for 1 cow received from the heriot of Robert de Boleworth. And 1 cow remains.

Calf

And for 1 calf received from issue of the aforesaid cow. And sold with lactage. And none remain.

Doe goats

And for 5 doe goats that remained. Sum as shown. And 5 doe goats remain.

Yearlings

And for 6 yearlings that remained from issue of the past year, of which 1 is a buck. Sum as shown. And 6 yearlings remain, of which 1 is a buck.

Kids

And for 5 kids received from issue of the aforesaid doe goats this year. And for 2 kids from issue of 2 yearlings. Sum 7. Of which in tithe 1. And 6 kids remain.

Hens

And for 5 cocks and 5 hens received from 'churchscot' at the feast of Christmas. Sum 10. And all were sold. And none remain.

Faggots

And for 700 faggots of alder made from alders at Northwode. Sum as shown. And all in the expenses of the lord at Esher. And none remain.

27. c. 29 September 1331 to c. 29 September 1332

Drought returned emphatically in 1331, with barely any rain falling between the beginning of March and the middle of June that year.⁴⁴¹ The Esher account covering that period details the impact that fire could have on tinder-dry buildings, with the burning of the oxshed and the complete destruction of a chamber above the gate.⁴⁴² With that exception, the effects of this drought are more apparent in the following account, for 1331/2. Here, for example, we are informed of the failure of crops, especially spring-sown barley and oats, as 'the greatest part remained in the ground due to drought through the whole of the countryside'. In such circumstances, it seems that even compromised meat was perceived to be better than a lack of food altogether, for 3 oxen were sold in London despite the 'suspicion of murrain'. Interestingly, we also see strategies being developed on the demesne to counter some of the problems that drought presented. For the first time in over 20 years, more land was sown at Northwode, where the soils were better able to retain moisture, than at Esher itself. Similarly, as there was now very little livestock kept at Esher, the use of available manure was carefully targeted and precisely recorded: in 1330/1, Longforlong had been manured by hand and was now sown with rye; in 1331/2, La Cleye was similarly targeted. Tenants on the dry Esher soils were plainly affected, too: with the exception of the year of the Black Death, perquisites of court were higher in 1331/2 than in any other year in the fourteenth century; and Gilbert le Forest, who had been reeve

⁴⁴¹ Stone, 'Impact of drought', pp. 438–9.

⁴⁴² HRO, 11M59/B1/84.